n8n Renewals Specialist: challenge submission

Paula Zabala. Scenario date: **Tuesday 20 October 2026.** Mid-October keeps the brief's premise: one renewal overdue and nine due within 60 days.

Summary

Part 1: Triage and forecast

- I rank by **slack** (days left against the work still needed) × ARR at risk.
- Northwind, Vantage and Pixelforge each need about an hour of work today to remove most of their risk. Halden (€45k, red) and Tessera (€50k, MSA redlines) get **escalated today**.
- **The forecast is driven by Renewal Status × days to renewal.**
  - Manual renewals: later statuses rise as the date approaches, early ones fall.
  - Auto-renewals have their own statuses.
  - Overdue renewals only count if they close within the quarter.
- **Today: €133k weighted. By 30 Oct: €245k if this week's actions land, €119k if nothing is done.** The countdown lowers early statuses on its own, so this week's work is worth about €126k of forecast.
- **Lost:** €23k regrettable contraction (Halden, Quanta) and a €3.6k price concession (Brightloop ramp, year 1). That's 92.9% gross and net retention.
- The number I'm least sure about: Halden.

Part 2: Brightloop

- I decline the termination right, auto-renewal removal and the 25% discount. Renewal values already include the 5% uplift. Procurement chooses between two structures:
  - **Ramp:** keep the plan, pay annually. €32,400 → €35,910, 7.4% total, Finance approval.
  - **Downsize + lock:** pay upfront. €28,800 a year for 2 or 3 years, net 60.
- **Walk-away:** no termination right, and no more than 12% off the current plan. Below that, a smaller plan at list price.

Part 3: Automation

- I extended my own n8n renewal-alerts workflow. Every morning it takes each renewal with an approved CPQ quote, has AI draft the email, waits for my approval, then sends it with the order form and sets the CRM status to *Quoted*.
- It chases unsigned order forms on days 3 and 7, alerts the CSM on at-risk accounts, and reminds me when a quote isn't ready. Numbers always come from the approved quote.

What's in the pack

File	What it is
`n8n_renewals_challenge_Paula_Zabala.pdf`	The submission: Parts 1–3
`brightloop_one_pager.pdf`	The one-page negotiation plan for Part 2
`renewal_tracker.xlsx`	The model behind the numbers: triage, pipeline, product lines, churn, monthly report, probability matrix
`crm_design_appendix.pdf`	Appendix: how the process lives in Salesforce (fields, formulas, guardrails, alerts, reports)

File	What it is
`ai_use_statement.pdf`	How I used AI: what came from me, what AI did, how I checked it
n8n workflow JSON	Importable into your own n8n

How I used AI and automation

In short (details in `ai_use_statement.pdf`):

- **My process and judgement:** the stage and probability logic, product-line and churn model, uplift and price-lock rules, account calls and the Brightloop packages.
- **An AI assistant (Claude):** pressure-tested the maths, drafted text I edited, and built the Excel model and n8n workflow from my specifications. I reviewed every number.
- **n8n:** Part 3 extends a workflow I'd already built, with the same principles as my renewal quotation agent at Bizzdesign: numbers from the tool of record, AI only for language, a human on every customer-facing output.

Part 1: Portfolio triage and forecast

As of Tuesday 20 October 2026. This puts Vantage Freight 5 days overdue and the other nine renewals inside 60 days, as the brief describes. Workbook: `renewal_tracker.xlsx`. Every number below comes from it.

How I rank

I rank on **slack**: the days left minus the days the work still needs, weighted by ARR at risk. A €48k renewal that is 9 days out with no quote sent comes before a €50k renewal that is 29 days out. Three of the renewals need only an hour of my time today to remove most of their risk. I do those first, before the long, multi-party ones.

The book by renewal month (my base report, and what every alert keys off):

Quarter	Month	#	Base ARR	Overdue	Manual, no quote, ≤60 days
Q4 2026	Oct	2	€69k	€21k	1
Q4 2026	Nov	5	€184k	–	3
Q4 2026	Dec	3	€122k	–	1
Total		**10**	**€375k**	**€21k**	**5**

The brief mentions a quote only for Vantage and Brightloop, so I treat the other five manual renewals as not quoted. On that basis, the 60-day quote policy has already been missed on five of them. That is a process gap, not a problem with individual deals. The CRM's 60-day quote task and Part 3 address it.

Ranked actions

#	Customer	ARR	Due	Why now	Next action	Who does what	Date
1	**Northwind Logistics**	€48k	29 Oct (9d)	Biggest near-term ARR, no quote, signed 3 days late last year	Send quote and order form for e-signature today at **€48k** (the renewal value, uplift included). Ask the champion who signs and whether a PO is needed. Book the signature for 27 Oct.	**Me:** quote, order form, signatory, signature on 27 Oct	**Today**
2	**Vantage Freight**	€21k	15 Oct (**overdue**)	Every day overdue costs credibility and cash. The shared inbox is the blocker, not the price.	The CSM looks up who owns and administers their n8n instance (names and emails from our product data), so we have real people to contact instead of the shared inbox. I phone and email a named person and agree a signing date. The manager confirms the grace period before access is restricted.	**CSM:** finds the instance owner and admins **Me:** calls them and agrees a signing date **Manager:** confirms the grace period	21 Oct
3	**Pixelforge**	€26k	2 Nov (13d)	Auto-renewal will fail on the expired card. That is involuntary churn on a green account.	The CSM gets the billing contact today. I send a secure card-update link, or switch them to invoice. Finance pauses the automatic failed-payment process (reminder emails, retries and suspending access) until the card is fixed. It renews at €26k.	**CSM:** finds the billing contact **Me:** card-update link or switch to invoice **Finance:** pauses the failed-payment process	22 Oct

#	Customer	ARR	Due	Why now	Next action	Who does what	Date
4	**Halden Health**	€45k	7 Nov (18d)	Red account, usage −35%, champion gone, nobody knows the new owner	**Escalate today** to my manager and VP CS. The CSM and an exec sponsor meet the new owner this week, with a value review before any quote. Legal checks whether the cancellation-notice date (8 Oct) passed without notice. I prepare a right-sized option at list price.	**CSM (lead):** meets the new owner, value review **Exec sponsor:** joins that meeting **Legal:** checks the 8 Oct notice date **Me:** escalates, prepares the right-sized option	23 Oct
5	**Tessera Finance**	€50k	18 Nov (29d)	MSA redlines open since September and a security review not yet started. Both can block the PO.	**Escalate today** to Legal. I get the list of open redlines, sort out the few that block their PO, and agree our positions on those with Legal in advance. One joint redline call (their legal, ours, me) with a response deadline of **30 Oct**. I send the quote and security pack today (SOC 2, pen-test summary, DPA, sub-processors), so the security review runs in parallel. **Fallback**, agreed with Legal and Finance now: a 1–2 month extension at current terms if the MSA isn't signed by 18 Nov.	**Legal (lead):** positions on PO-blocking redlines, joint call, response by 30 Oct **Me:** redline list, quote and security pack, runs the timeline **Finance + Legal:** approve the extension fallback	23 Oct
6	**Brightloop**	€36k	14 Dec (55d)	Live negotiation, and procurement is setting the pace	Reply to Sam today (see Part 2). Get Finance pre-approval before the call. Call Sam and Priya on 22–23 Oct. Target signature 30 Nov.	**Me:** reply to Sam, the call, the order form **Finance:** pre-approves up to 12% and net 60 **VP CS:** pre-approves the buffer	**Today**
7	**Marlowe Insurance**	€46k	9 Dec (50d)	Insurance procurement is slow. Without the questionnaire and DPA there is no PO.	Send the standard DPA and the questionnaire, answered from the trust centre (AI first draft, Security reviews). Send the quote with it. Ask for their PO lead time and work back from 9 Dec.	**Me:** quote, questionnaire, PO lead time **Security:** reviews the questionnaire answers **Legal:** the DPA	27 Oct
8	**Kestrel Analytics**	€35k	28 Nov (39d)	Usage +40%, close to the execution cap. Expansion, and a risk of throttling.	The CSM runs a usage review and approves the proposed tier. I then send one quote that separates the **renewal** (like-for-like, €35k) from the **upsell** (the next execution tier) as distinct lines, so the customer sees what renews and what's new. The upsell is booked on its own linked Upsell opportunity. If the upsell slows things down, we sign the renewal and add the upsell later as an amendment.	**CSM:** usage review, approves the tier **Me:** one quote, renewal and upsell on separate lines; upsell opportunity	28 Oct

#	Customer	ARR	Due	Why now	Next action	Who does what	Date
9	**Lumen Retail**	€28k	21 Nov (32d)	Auto-renewal, but the invoice would go to the wrong entity. Cancellation deadline 22 Oct (assumed 30 days).	Get the new entity's name, VAT number and address. Legal decides whether this is a billing change (affiliate) or an assignment (new order form). Finance updates billing before the invoice run.	**Me:** gets the new entity's details **Legal:** billing change or assignment **Finance:** updates billing before the invoice run	22 Oct
10	**Quanta Labs**	€40k	19 Dec (60d)	Auto-renewal, usage −20%, budget cuts in Q1, two check-ins unanswered	The CSM and exec sponsor go in through a new contact (economic buyer or finance). I confirm the cancellation-notice date (~19 Nov). I offer an in-policy **2-year price lock** or a right-size *before* they decide to cancel.	**CSM + exec sponsor:** reach a new contact **Me:** confirms the notice date, offers the lock or right-size	30 Oct

Escalations I raise today

1. **Halden Health (€45k, red, 18 days).** To my manager and VP CS. I need an exec sponsor on a call with the new owner this week.
2. **Tessera Finance (€50k).** To the Legal lead: redlines have been open for 6+ weeks, and I need a response by 30 Oct, our positions on the PO-blocking clauses agreed in advance, and the extension fallback approved.
3. **Vantage Freight (€21k, overdue).** To my manager: what is our grace period before access is restricted? I'd propose day 14 for exec-to-exec contact and day 30 for formal notice under the contract.
4. **Brightloop.** Not an escalation, but a pre-approval request to Finance (up to 12% on a 2-year deal, net 60). I want room to trade during the call.
5. **Process.** Five manual renewals inside 60 days have no quote on record, which breaks the quote policy. The fix is a 60-day quote task and alert in the CRM, plus Part 3, which sends the approved quote and chases the signature.

Forecast: driven by Renewal Status × countdown

Each renewal's **Renewal Status** is set from *what we know* today. Its probability comes from the status × days-to-renewal matrix. For manual renewals, late statuses rise as the date gets closer and early statuses fall, because no progress near the date is the risk. **Auto-renewals have their own statuses** (Renewing: no blockers · Billing blocker · At risk before or after the notice deadline · Notice received). On those, an open blocker or risk lowers the probability as the date approaches. **Weighted new ARR = new ARR from the product lines × probability.**

Customer	Days	What we know	Status today	Prob.	New ARR	Weighted	Bucket
Vantage Freight	−5	Quote sent 1 Sep, no reply	Quoted	50% (overdue)	€21,000	€10,500	Late
Northwind Logistics	9	No quote; champion says "just send it"; signatory unknown	Engaging customer	25%	€48,000	€12,000	Late
Pixelforge (auto)	13	Card expired, billing contact unknown	Billing blocker	60%	€26,000	€15,600	Late
Halden Health	18	Champion left; new owner not met	Not started	10%	€30,000	€3,000	Late

Customer	Days	What we know	Status today	Prob.	New ARR	Weighted	Bucket
Tessera Finance	29	MSA redlines; security review	Negotiation	40%	€50,000	€20,000	Late
Lumen Retail (auto)	32	Invoice to a different entity	Billing blocker	70%	€28,000	€19,600	On time
Kestrel Analytics	39	Near execution cap	Not started	20%	€35,000	€7,000	On time
Marlowe Insurance	50	Needs questionnaire and DPA for a PO	Engaging customer	35%	€46,000	€16,100	On time
Brightloop	55	Live negotiation	Negotiation	50%	€32,400	€16,200	On time
Quanta Labs (auto)	60	Usage −20%, silent, Q1 budget cuts	At risk: before notice deadline	40%	€32,000	€12,800	On time
Total					**€348,400**	**€132,800**	

Overdue rule. Overdue renewals use their own, lower probability column and are always **Late**. They still count in the quarter **only if the expected close date is on or before quarter end**. Vantage is overdue since 15 Oct but expected by 6 Nov, so it counts in Q4. A renewal that slips past quarter end counts 0% for that quarter and returns next quarter as a late renewal. So I report two numbers: **quarter retention** (did we keep the revenue?) and **on-time rate** (did we close by the renewal date?).

Notice deadlines. The brief gives a 30-day cancellation notice only for Halden (deadline 8 Oct, already passed). For the three auto-renewals I've **assumed 30 days**, to confirm against each contract. That gives Pixelforge 3 Oct (passed), Lumen 22 Oct (in two days; low risk, as they are green and growing) and Quanta ~19 Nov. The 5% uplift is contractual, announced to all customers in one notice each January, and already included in every renewal value.

Usage rule. n8n prices by workflow executions, not users.

- **Over-usage** (+20% or more, e.g. Kestrel at +40%): renew as is, open a linked Upsell opportunity, and set a task to propose the right tier. No automatic charge unless the contract has an overage clause. It's upside, not in the forecast.
- **Under-usage** (−20% or more, e.g. Halden and Quanta): flag the CSM for an adoption plan. Auto-renewals move to *At risk*.

Q4 forecast (today)	Weighted new ARR	Unweighted
On time	**€72k**	€173k (5 renewals)
Late, still in Q4 (overdue, or still early or blocked inside 30 days)	**€61k**	€175k (Vantage, Northwind, Pixelforge, Halden, Tessera)
Slips past quarter end	€0	none today
Total weighted forecast	**€133k**	€348k

Forecast of the forecast: with action vs no action

The probability depends on status **and** days to renewal, so the forecast moves even if nobody does anything. On **30 Oct** every renewal is 10 days closer:

- **With this week's actions**, each status moves to the target below.
- **With no action**, statuses stay where they are and the countdown alone lowers the early ones.

Customer	Today → target by 30 Oct	Weighted today	🟢 With actions, 30 Oct	🔴 No action, 30 Oct
Northwind	Engaging → PO received (signature 27 Oct)	€12,000	€45,600	€4,800
Tessera	Negotiation → Quoted (quote and security pack out, redline call booked)	€20,000	€37,500	€20,000
Kestrel	Not started → Quoted	€7,000	€26,250	€3,500
Marlowe	Engaging → Quoted	€16,100	€32,200	€16,100
Pixelforge	Billing blocker → Renewing: no blockers (card updated)	€15,600	€25,220	€15,600
Lumen	Billing blocker → Renewing: no blockers (entity fixed)	€19,600	€27,160	€16,800
Vantage	Quoted → Waiting for PO (named signer)	€10,500	€14,700	€10,500
Halden	Not started → Engaging customer (new owner met)	€3,000	€7,500	€3,000
Brightloop, Quanta	No change this week	€29,000	€29,000	€29,000
Total		**€133k**	**€245k**	**€119k**

- **Doing nothing costs about €13.5k of forecast in 10 days** (€133k → €119k). Northwind turns overdue and Kestrel and Lumen move into their last 30 days.
- **This week's actions add about €112k** (€133k → €245k). Against doing nothing, that's **€126k of difference on 30 Oct**.
- Northwind, Tessera, Kestrel and Marlowe carry about €86k of the gain, which is why they sit at the top of the triage.

Lost. This comes from the product lines, and churn is split by type:

	Amount	Accounts
Regrettable churn/contraction (revenue lost to n8n for good)	**−€23k**	Halden −€15k (right-sized), Quanta −€8k (budget cut)
Non-regrettable (a line churns but is replaced by another n8n product, e.g. self-hosted Enterprise → n8n Cloud)	€0	none in this slice
Price concession below current price	−€3.6k	Brightloop (ramp year 1, 10% off)

- **Gross retention 92.9%** (base less regrettable churn and concessions). Every renewal value already includes the 5% uplift, so nothing is added on top.
- **Kestrel upsell is upside, not in the forecast.** It's worth roughly +€10–15k if they move up a tier.
- The gap between €348k and the €133k weighted forecast is **risk, not loss**. Moving each deal to the next status closes it, which is what the ranked actions above are for.

The number I'm least sure about: Lost (€23k regrettable)

Halden alone ranges from €0 to €45k. There's no relationship with the new owner, usage is down 35%, and I don't yet know whether the 8 Oct notice date locked in the renewal. Quanta is second: if a cancellation notice lands before ~19 Nov (an assumed 30-day notice), that's €40k, not €8k. On timing, **Tessera** is the least certain: Late versus on time depends on Legal and their security team.

How the CRM supports this

Statuses, the probability matrix, product lines (renewal, upsell, downgrade, churn, with original vs new ARR), the uplift (built into the renewal value) and price lock, churn category and reason, alerts and reports all live in Salesforce. **The full design is in the appendix (`crm_design_appendix.pdf`), and `renewal_tracker.xlsx` is a working mock-up of it.**

Part 2: Brightloop negotiation

A. My reply to Sam (sent Tue 20 Oct)

> **Subject:** Brightloop renewal: two ways to make it fit your budget
>
> Hi Sam,
>
> Thank you for being this open about the budget pressure. That makes it much easier to find something that works.
>
> First, the two support escalations this year. They took longer to resolve than they should have, and I'm sorry. I've asked our support lead to review both, and I'll bring what we find and what we're changing to our call.
>
> On procurement's four points: a 25% discount, removing auto-renewal and a termination-for-convenience right are outside what we offer on any Enterprise renewal, so I can't agree to those. Net 60 is possible, depending on the structure we choose. Either way, I'm confident we can bring your cost down to a level that works for your budget. I'd like to walk you and Priya through two options:
>
> - **Keep your current plan, with a lower cost this year.** A multi-year structure where this year costs less than today, and over two years you pay no more than you do now.
> - **Right-size and lock the price.** We look at your actual execution data together, set your plan to what you really use, and lock that price for two or three years.
>
> Both would come with our highest support tier.
>
> Could we set up 30 minutes with you and Priya on Thursday or Friday? It would help to know the budget you need to land on (and whether the pressure is on this year's spend or on cash) and who signs. If you're weighing other options, I'm happy to explore together which solution fits best and what it would mean in practice.
>
> With your renewal on 14 December, agreeing terms by the end of November leaves plenty of time for the paperwork.
>
> Best, Paula Renewals, n8n

Why this email:

- It opens with the support problem, which is the real emotional issue.
- It says no to the four asks once, clearly, without arguing each one in writing.
- It offers two directions, not prices, so the numbers are discussed live with the decision makers.

B. One-page negotiation plan

Attached as `brightloop_one_pager.pdf`. In short:

- **Target: two structures, procurement chooses.**
  - **Ramp** (keep the plan, pay annually): €32,400 → €35,910. That's €68,310 over 2 years, about 5% less than staying at €36,000 a year. 7.4% vs the indexed list path, Finance approval.

    - **Downsize + lock** (pay upfront): a lower execution allowance at list price, €28,800 a year locked for 2 or 3 years, net 60.
    - **Both:** top support tier, no downgrade during the term, auto-renewal applies only after the term.
- **Walk-away:** no termination right, and auto-renewal stays. On the current plan, no more than 12% off list (a 2-year total of at least €64,944). Below that, they downsize at list price.
- **In reserve:** a downgrade buffer on the ramp, up to 10% at the year-2 anniversary, pre-approved by the VP.
- **What I trade:** every give is tied to a get (multi-year term, upfront payment, signature by 30 Nov).
- **Who's involved:** Finance, VP CS, Legal, CSM and the support lead are lined up before the call.

C. Call playbook (15 minutes, I keep time)

Min	Segment	What I do
0–1	Open	Agenda, time check, confirm who decides and who signs
1–4	Discovery (Sam)	Budget figure; **cash or this year's cost?**; fiscal year; why executions fell 10% (seasonal, a project ended, moving work elsewhere)
4–6	Support	Own the two escalations, share the remediation plan and the top support tier
6–10	Options (Priya joins)	Show both options side by side; lead with the one discovery points to
10–13	Trade	Only "if… then…". One concession for each thing I get back. Never split the difference.
13–15	Close	Summarise, name an owner for each open item, set the date the order form goes out, confirm signature by 30 Nov

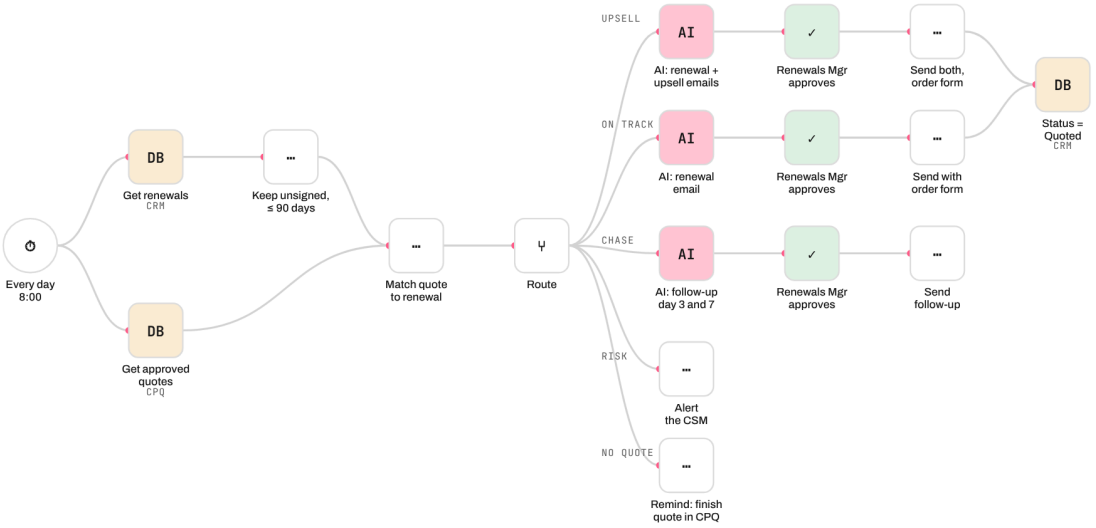
Surprises I expect, and how I'd answer

They say	I answer
"We have a competitor quote 40% cheaper."	"Can you share what's in scope? Most quotes leave out migration, rebuilding the workflows, and Enterprise controls." I don't match the price. I offer the ramp or the downsize.
"We'll just self-host the free version."	It's a real option. I walk through what they'd lose (SSO, environments, Git, log streaming, SLA support) and the DevOps cost, and offer a technical session with Sam.
"Net 60 is company policy."	"I can do net 60 when the contract is paid upfront: that's the downsize + lock option."
"We want the price lock but we pay annually."	"The lock comes with upfront payment. Paying annually, the ramp gives you this year's relief instead."
"All four points, or no deal."	"I can't do the exit clause or remove auto-renewal for anyone. What problem are they solving for you?" Then I solve that problem: the buffer, the reminder, and the clause applying only after the term.
"Fine, 3 years for 25% off."	"3 years changes the picture, and I'll take it to my VP. I can't commit to 25%." I come back within 48 hours.
Priya: "Our budget is €30k."	That fits downsize + lock (€28.8k). If they need the full plan, the ramp's year 1 is €32.4k, and I check whether a 12% year 1 (€31,680) (still within Finance's limit) closes the gap.
Silence until 14 Dec	The offers expire on 30 Nov. If nothing is signed by 1 Dec, I escalate exec to exec.

Debrief line: "I moved the conversation from *discount* to *structure*: they chose between keeping the plan with a ramp, or a smaller plan with a locked price. Every concession was traded, and nothing reset the price."

Part 3: From approved quote to signature, every morning

I extended my own n8n workflow, *Daily renewal alerts*, which I built before this challenge. It now covers the part of the renewal that eats the most time once a quote exists: emailing the customer, sending the order form, updating the CRM and chasing the signature. At 221 renewals a quarter, this is where days slip.



Pink AI steps draft the email · green ✓ steps wait for a person's approval · DB steps read from or write to the CRM and CPQ.

What it does, step by step

1. **Every morning at 8:00** it reads the renewals due within 90 days that aren't signed yet, and pulls the quotes already **approved in the CPQ**.
2. **It matches each renewal to its approved quote**, so every email uses the exact offer, order form and quote number the customer will sign.
3. **It routes each renewal to one of five paths:**
    - **On track:** AI drafts the renewal email around the approved offer → I approve it → it goes out with the order form for e-signature.
    - **Upsell** (usage above the plan): AI drafts the renewal email and a separate upsell email → I approve both → both go out.
    - **Chase signature:** 3 and 7 days after sending, if it isn't signed, AI drafts a short follow-up → I approve → it goes out.
    - **Risk** (red health, usage dropping): no customer email. The CSM gets an alert to act first.
    - **No quote yet:** I get a reminder to finish the quote in the CPQ before the deadline slips.
4. **Nothing reaches a customer without my click.** Each draft arrives in my inbox with Approve and Reject buttons (Gmail send-and-wait), and the workflow waits.
5. **After sending, it writes back to the CRM:** status *Quoted* and the date sent. That date starts the signature chase.

Why this design: the numbers come from the approved quote, never from the AI, and a person approves everything that reaches a customer. AI does the writing, where it saves the most time. **How I'd know it works:** quote out by day 60, 1 of 7 → **100%** · approved quote to sent: **same day** · signed within 7 days: tracked · AI drafts approved without edits: tracked. **Tested** on five accounts, one per path, with no real emails sent. The prototype uses Google Sheet tabs in place of Salesforce and the CPQ, and the workflow JSON is attached.